

What else to watch: *The Searchers* (1956, p.135) ■ *The Good, the Bad and the Ugly* (1966) ■ *Bonnie and Clyde* (1967, pp.190–91) ■ *Once Upon a Time in the West* (1968, p.336) ■ *Bring Me the Head of Alfredo Garcia* (1974)



“We gotta start thinking beyond our guns,” one of the bandits observes; “Those days are closing.” The movie celebrates male bonding, but the sun is setting on this bunch of outsiders.

The Wild Bunch questions the motives of the law while also displaying sympathy for the outlaws, their loyalty and self-reliance. The movie’s final confrontation is set in motion by the bunch’s decision to try to save their captured comrade, Angel (Jaime Sánchez). Many of the law enforcers that trail the bunch, by contrast, are shown to be incompetent and corrupt. The movie becomes a humane exploration of the cost of living in amoral times, presenting outlaws as a product of their surroundings. It finds a compassion for its characters that the Westerns of old could not. ■

begins and ends with anarchic set pieces of violence. In each scene, innocents are caught in the cross fire as both sides shoot almost blindly at anything that moves. There is no right or wrong

in these scenes, just a struggle to survive. This was perhaps a more honest portrayal of the West than the moralizing take of the previous generation of Westerns, in which the good prevail in the end.

Tector (Ben Johnson), Lyle (Warren Oates), Pike (William Holden), and Dutch (Ernest Borgnine) walk out to save Angel. They will stick together to the end.

“We’re after men. And I wish to God I was with them.”

Deke Thornton /
The Wild Bunch

